

MANDAL COMMISSION

■ By S. Prasannarajan

In the Indian history of resistance, that flaming metaphor was something new. The sacrificial rite of Rajeev Goswami, a 20-year-old graduate student from Delhi University, was a rejoinder—naïvely romantic but powerful—to the politics of denial and division. His self-immolation, the first notation of aborted martyrdom, momentarily brought Delhi close to those barricaded streets of Paris, 1968, though the political as well as the cultural context was different. Suddenly, pitted against the political order was the power of youth. Students became the force of dissent and change. They wanted freedom from the most divisive M-word before Modi. Mandal partitioned the mind of India, and it reinforced the truism that caste is the last refuge of the des-

perate politician.

In the beginning of the last decade of the last century, the desperation of prime minister Viswanath Pratap Singh was camouflaged in a huge pretence. The man who spoke from the ramparts of the Red Fort on Independence Day in 1990 was playing to history. He had the grand gesture, and words to match. The Raja of Manda was all set for the revolutionary sweep. In retrospect, it was political kitsch at its mass-mesmerising best. He not only declared his determination to implement the Mandal Commission report—which recommended 27.5 per cent reservations in government jobs for the Other Backward Classes. He said he would make the Prophet's birthday a national holiday.

NO WAY: Students protest against reservation in Kolkata in 2006

MALKU RAM, a Harijan IGP in Bihar, 1990

"Not implementing reservation should be a cognisable offence."

Divide and RULE

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